The Guardian

one stop english

How to quit fast fashion: 'Sometimes we don't need retail therapy, we need actual therapy'

Level 3: Elementary

1 Warmer

a. Read the definitions below. Then, discuss the questions with a partner.

fast fashion: cheap clothing produced quickly and sold in large quantities to respond the latest fashion trends

- Does shopping make you happy?
- Do you think most people buy too many clothes?
- How is *fast fashion* bad for the planet?

2 Key words

a. Choose the word from the article that best matches each definition.

brain **brand** **joy** **unsubscribe** **wage**

1. Your _____ is the organ inside your head that allows you to think and feel, and controls your body.
2. A _____ is a product or group of products that has its own name and is made by one particular company. The word for a machine or vehicle made by one particular company is a 'make'.
3. A _____ is an amount of money that you earn for working, usually according to how many hours or days you work each week or month.
4. _____ is a feeling of great happiness.
5. To _____ is to take your name off an internet mailing list.

browse **engage** **environmental** **order** **style**

6. If you _____ something, you design and shape it.
7. To _____ means to look at things in a shop without being sure whether you want to buy anything.

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8. To _____ means to take part in a particular activity, especially one that involves competing with other people or talking to them.
9. The word _____ means relating to the natural world and the effect that human activity has on it.
10. When you _____ a product, you ask for someone to make it or deliver it to you.

b. Complete the sentences using words from task a.

1. Do you care what _____ your clothes are?
2. People spend most of their _____ on rent.
3. Do you _____ for a long time before you _____ new clothes?
4. Do your clothes bring you _____?

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Lucianne Tonti
28 November, 2022

1 It can be difficult to quit fast fashion. Psychologist Chris Cheers says first you have to look at the ideas behind your actions. He says you might believe, "If I don't buy this, I can't go to a party." Look at the thought and understand you don't have to believe it.

2 Cheers says that if your brain is saying you'll be more popular in the new shirt, think about it. Is a new shirt going to get you the life that you want? "Sometimes we don't need retail therapy, we need actual therapy," he says.

3 Here, people who no longer buy fast fashion share their tips to change your buying habits.

The rule of three

4 In 2019, Lauren Bravo, the author of How To Break Up With Fast Fashion, decided not to buy anything new for a year. Now she never buys anything new without thinking about it for weeks or months. She studies brands and buys only from those who pay their workers a good wage.

5 She thinks about how an item will fit into her wardrobe and uses her mum's rule before buying anything: name at least three items in your wardrobe you would wear it with, and three places you will wear it to. She also believes in the joy of saving up for something.

The unfollower

6 Writer and podcaster Maggie Zhou follows the '30 Wears' rule. This means you must try to wear an item of clothing at least 30 times. She has also unfollowed fast-fashion brands on social media and unsubscribed from email lists. She says that style comes from wearing and styling clothes again in different ways.

The no-buy browser

7 "I know myself, and I know I'm not going to stop shopping," says Wendy Syfret, author of The Sunny Nihilist. She browses non-shopping sites like Pinterest and Instagram. "I make boards and saved folders of looks I like or brands I'm interested in," she says.

The educated switcher

8 Nico Idour says, "I just do not engage any more." The owner of Jawbreaker the Baker has changed his shopping habits since meeting his husband, designer Jason Hewitt. Hewitt explained the "realities of fast fashion" and the environmental costs of mass production and international shipping. Quitting fast fashion was easy for Idour when he understood this. Now he shops second-hand and always tries something on before he buys it, which stops him from ordering things quickly online.

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First published in The Guardian, 28/11/2022

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3 Comprehension check

a. Who said it? Read the sentences below and write the name of who said them.

1. Stop following fashion brands on social media.
2. Don't believe everything you think.
3. Learn about the environmental costs of fast fashion.
4. Browse and save pictures of clothes online instead of buying clothes.
5. Ask yourself why you want to shop more.
6. Don't buy new clothes.
7. Wear the same clothes differently.
8. Before buying an item, think where you'd wear it to.

4 Key language

a. Match the words to make word pairs from the article.

1. fast	therapy
2. retail	habits
3. shopping	brands
4. fashion	fashion
5. environmental	shipping
6. international	costs

b. Fill in the gaps with word pairs from the previous activity.

1. I buy too many things that I don't need. I really need to change my _____.
2. The shirt only costs £5, but _____ is an extra £10. It will arrive in three to four weeks.
3. _____ doesn't really make you feel happy. You only feel better for a short while after buying something.
4. Fast fashion is cheap, but the _____ are high. It's terrible for the planet.
5. I don't care about _____. I buy things I like and don't look at the brand names.

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5 Discussion

a. Discuss the following statements.

- "People shouldn't buy cheap clothes. It is bad for the planet."
- "No one needs more than five pairs of shoes."
- "There should be more places where people can buy second-hand clothes."

6 In your own words

a. Write an email to a friend telling them about the article. Follow the steps below.

1. What is the article about?
2. Did it make you think about your own shopping habits?
3. Give your own opinion about fast fashion.
4. Why should your friend read the article?

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